UPSC CIVIL SERVICES MAINS | ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL | PAPER I

Topic 6 — Part J
Postmodernism in Anthropology

Exact syllabus wording covered: "Anthropological theories: ... (j) Post-modernism in anthropology."

What this topic is really about. Every theory before this one assumed that an anthropologist could go somewhere, observe a culture and write down a true account of it. Postmodernism asks **who gets to write that account, in whose words, with what authority, and for whom**. It treats ethnography as a **text** made with rhetoric, power and partial vision, distrusts all **grand theories**, and insists that culture is contested and plural rather than a bounded whole. The examiner now wants two things from it: its **features**, and its **uses and limits** — especially for the people anthropology has written about.

Study window	Opens 11 Nov 2026 — **1 day** (two sessions), per your Subject Coverage row
Estimated study time	3 hr first pass, including one written 20-mark answer
Revision time	20 min full note • 6 min one-page sheet (Section 15)
Study as	Three units — the features (2015), Derrida and deconstruction (2024), and justice for the marginalised (2025). Fig. 1 serves all three.
Note status	Draft 1 — for your review. Not final until you sign it off.
Boundary	Geertz's interpretive anthropology is **6-H**; Lévi-Strauss is **6-D**; fieldwork methods and ethics are **Topic 8**; colonial history of Indian anthropology is **Paper II, unit 4**.

Candid verdict — the live end of Topic 6, and rising. Four stems: **2012** (note, 12 marks), **2015** (basic features, 20), **2024** (Derrida and deconstruction, 20) and **2025** (postmodernism, social justice and the marginalised, 20) — **72 marks**, and **back-to-back 20-markers** in the last two years before 2026, which had none. The stems have moved from "describe it" to "name a philosopher" and then to "apply it". Your tracker has PYQ Count 2 and Mains Value High; the count should be **4** and High is right. The adjacent load is heavy too: the 2020 question on how anthropological writing changed (15), multi-sited ethnography (2025), culture as an "integrated-closed system" (2025, 15) and the colonial history of Indian anthropology (2024, Paper II) all want this material.

2 SCOPE MAP

What is included

- **What postmodernism is** — the condition and the theory, Lyotard's "incredulity toward metanarratives", and its eight working features.
- **The philosophers** — Lyotard, Derrida, Foucault, Baudrillard, Jameson — one line each, with Derrida in depth.
- **Why anthropology took it up** — decolonisation, the Malinowski diary, Asad, Said, Fabian, feminism, Geertz's textual turn.
- **The anthropological canon** — *Writing Culture* and *Anthropology as Cultural Critique* (both 1986), Clifford, Marcus, Fischer, Tyler, Rosaldo, Abu-Lughod.
- **The basic features of postmodern anthropology** — the 2015 question.
- **Derrida and deconstruction** — the 2024 question, including his critique of Lévi-Strauss.
- **Postmodernism and social justice** — the 2025 question: uses, limits and the fix.

- **Criticism and legacy**; **Indian material** — Subaltern Studies, Cohn and Dirks, Gopal Guru, Niyamgiri.

What is excluded, and where it belongs

Material	Belongs to	Why it is kept out
Thick description; the cockfight; culture as text in Geertz's own sense	6-H, done	Geertz is named here as precursor; one comparison table (11.2)
Lévi-Strauss's structural method	6-D, done	Only as the object of Derrida's critique
Tyler's cognitive phase	6-I, done	His 1986 essay is used here; the cognitive work is there
Fieldwork techniques; research ethics codes	Topic 8	Reflexivity is the bridge; methods are there
Appadurai's global cultural economy	2.1 (2024)	Named as a postmodern-era descendant only
Colonial administrators and Indian anthropologists	Paper II, 4	Cohn and Dirks named here as the deconstructive reading

How it connects outward

- **6-H** — Geertz made ethnography an interpretation and the anthropologist an author; the postmodernists took the next step and questioned the author's authority.
- **6-D** — post-structuralism begins as a critique of structuralism: Derrida's 1966 lecture was aimed at Lévi-Strauss.
- **6-I** — Tyler's journey from formal models to "evocation" is the cleanest one-sentence history of the turn.
- **Topic 8** — the 2020 question on interpretation and presentation of data, the 2025 note on multi-sited and critical ethnography, the 2026 note on fieldwork ethics.
- **Paper II** — "tribe as a colonial construct" (2016), deconstructing the colonial history of Indian anthropology (2024), PVTG nomenclature (2024).

3 PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

Mains

2012 and 2015 wording and marks from your 1995–2021 compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 6(j)); 2024 and 2025 checked against the published papers.

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Marks
2025	How the theories of postmodernism are relevant in promoting social justice and empowerment of marginalised communities? (Q8a)	Application — uses and limits	20
2024	Critically explain the notion of 'deconstruction' in the light of the postmodern works of Jacques Derrida.	One thinker, one concept, critically	20
2015	Explain the basic features of 'Postmodernism' in Anthropology.	The features, with anthropologists	20
2012	Post-modernism in Anthropology (note, 150 words).	Definition plus features	12

Adjacent stems that reward this material (not counted)

Year	Question	What 6-J supplies
2026	Ethics in anthropological fieldwork (10)	Reflexivity, voice, consent
2025	Multispecies, multi-sited and critical ethnography (10)	Marcus 1995
2025	Drawbacks in assuming culture as an "integrated-closed system" (15)	Abu-Lughod; Gupta & Ferguson
2024	Paper II: deconstruct the colonial history of Indian anthropology (15)	Asad, Cohn, Dirks

Year	Question	What 6-J supplies
2024	Contemporary challenges in fieldwork (15)	Crisis of representation
2020	How have interpretation and presentation of data changed from classical to contemporary writings? (15)	*Writing Culture*, almost verbatim
2020	Experiential ethnography (10)	Rosaldo; reflexive fieldwork
2016	Paper II: tribe as a colonial construct (10)	Deconstruction of categories

Prelims

Not applicable. The optional is a Mains paper, and GS Prelims has not set postmodern anthropology. No Prelims facts are carried in this packet.

What UPSC is actually testing

Demand	Times	What is really being tested	Your reading
Features of postmodern anthropology	2 — 2012, 2015	Whether you can list the features **with anthropologists attached**, not only philosophers	5.5 plus Fig. 1. Master Answer 1
A named philosopher's concept	1 — 2024	Deconstruction explained, applied to anthropology, and criticised	5.6 plus Fig. 2. Master Answer 2
Application to justice and the marginalised	1 — 2025	What postmodern theory **does** for the powerless — and where it fails them	5.7 plus Fig. 3. Master Answer 3

Trend reading

- **Rising, and moving from description to application.** 2012 asked for a note; 2015 for features; 2024 for a named philosopher; 2025 for an application. The next stem is likely to be applied again — to development, identity, or Indian tribes.
- **Philosophers are now fair game.** 2024 named Derrida. Foucault (power/knowledge) and Lyotard (metanarratives) are the next most likely names. Prepare one paragraph on each.
- **"Critically" recurs.** Both 20-markers in 2024 and 2025 demand limits. A celebratory answer will not score.
- **Indian examples now decide the band.** The 2025 stem's "marginalised communities" is an invitation to Adivasi and Dalit cases. Carry two.

4 BIG-PICTURE CONCEPTUAL MAP

MOVE 1 — No grand narrative survives. Lyotard (1979): the postmodern is "incredulity toward metanarratives" — progress, reason, science, Marxism. In anthropology this means no master theory — not evolutionism, not functionalism, not structuralism — can claim the final word.

MOVE 2 — Ethnography is writing. An ethnography is a text made with rhetoric, selection and authorial power, not a mirror. Clifford (1986): ethnographic truths are "inherently partial". This is the **crisis of representation**.

MOVE 3 — Knowledge is tied to power. Foucault: what counts as knowledge is produced within relations of power. Anthropology's categories — primitive, tribe, caste — were made in the colonial encounter (Asad 1973; Said 1978).

MOVE 4 — So: reflexivity, many voices, open culture. The author positions himself; the people speak in their own voices (polyphony, dialogue); culture is seen as contested, hybrid and unbounded; new forms of writing are tried. *Fig. 1*

MOVE 5 — The gain and the price. It exposed hidden power and gave voice — useful to the marginalised. It also risked relativism, navel-gazing and a retreat from material inequality. The mature position keeps the critique and the commitment.

That chain is the shape of any long answer: **no metanarrative → ethnography as text → power/knowledge → reflexivity and voice → gains and limits.**

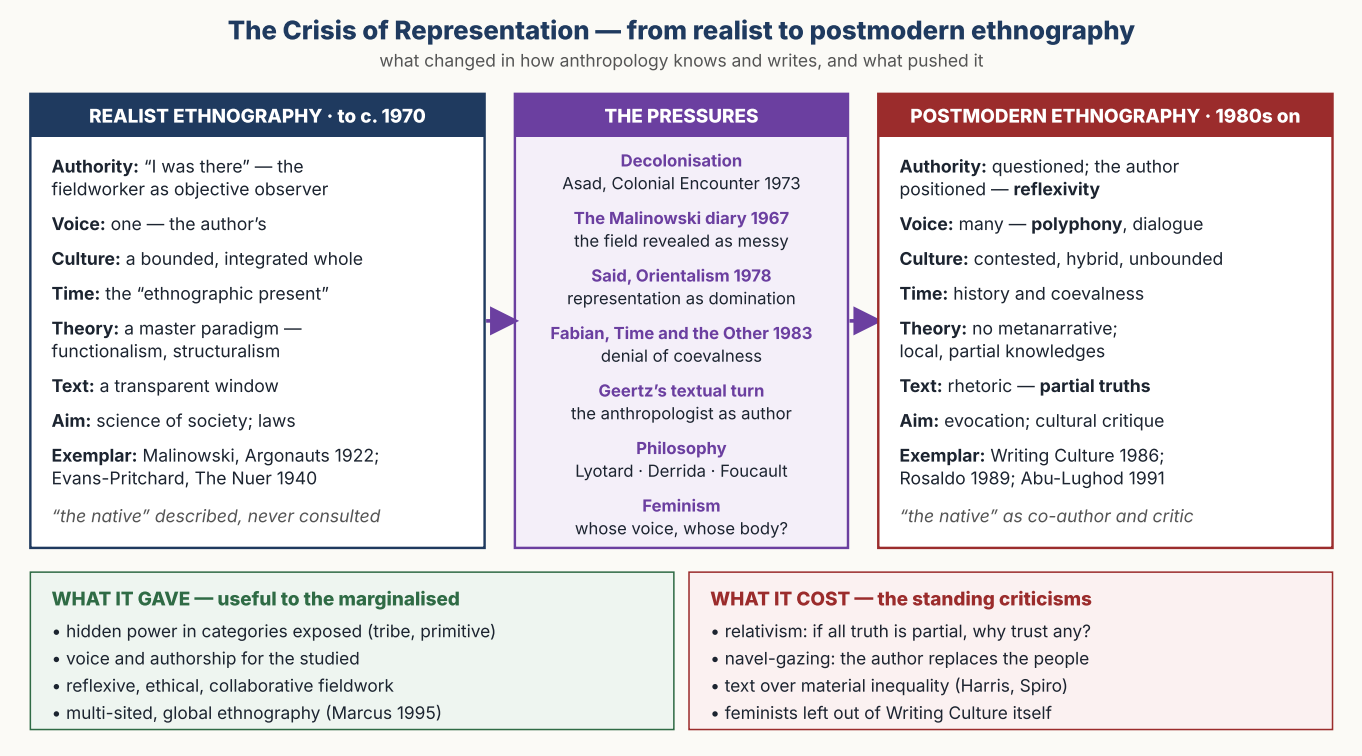


Fig. 1 — the hero diagram: realist against postmodern ethnography on eight bases, the pressures that drove the change, and the ledger of gains and costs. It serves the 2012, 2015 and 2025 questions alike.

5 CORE NOTES

5.1 What postmodernism is

Plain version. Postmodernism is a mood of suspicion towards big, confident stories — about progress, science, reason or "the primitive" — and towards anyone who claims to tell the whole truth about other people.

- **Working definition.** Postmodernism is a late-twentieth-century intellectual movement that rejects universal, foundational truths and grand explanatory theories, treats knowledge and identity as socially constructed, plural and bound up with power, and attends to language, representation and the position of the knower.
- **Condition and theory.** *Postmodernity* is a social condition — post-industrial, media-saturated, globalised, fragmented (Jameson's "cultural logic of late capitalism", 1984/1991). *Postmodernism* is the theoretical response. Say this distinction once.
- **Lyotard's formula.** *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge* (1979): the postmodern is "**incredulity toward metanarratives**". MEMORISE
- **Post-structuralism.** The French philosophical core (Derrida, Foucault, late Barthes) that grew out of structuralism by denying that structures are stable, centred or closed. In anthropology the two labels are used almost interchangeably.
- **In anthropology,** postmodernism is less a theory of culture than a **critique of how anthropology knows and writes** — the "reflexive" or "literary" turn of the 1980s.

5.2 The philosophers — one line each

Thinker	Work	Idea to carry into anthropology
Jean-François Lyotard	*The Postmodern Condition* (1979)	Incredulity toward metanarratives; knowledge as plural, local "language games"
Jacques Derrida	*Of Grammatology*, *Writing and Difference* (1967)	Deconstruction; binaries are hierarchies; meaning is never fully present — *différance* (5.6)

Thinker	Work	Idea to carry into anthropology
Michel Foucault	*The Archaeology of Knowledge* (1969); *Discipline and Punish* (1975); *History of Sexuality* I (1976)	**Power/knowledge**; discourse produces its objects; disciplinary power; genealogy
Jean Baudrillard	*Simulacra and Simulation* (1981)	Simulation and hyperreality — images without originals
Fredric Jameson	*Postmodernism, or, the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (1991)	Postmodernity as a stage of capitalism — a Marxist reading
Edward Said	*Orientalism* (1978)	Western knowledge of the East as a discourse of domination — the bridge into anthropology

5.3 Why anthropology turned — the pressures

- **Decolonisation and the colonial critique.** Talal Asad (ed.), *Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter* (1973): the discipline grew inside colonial power and shared its assumptions.
- **The Malinowski diary (1967).** *A Diary in the Strict Sense of the Term* showed the founder of fieldwork lonely, irritable and contemptuous — the objective observer was a literary pose.
- **Said's *Orientalism* (1978).** Representation of others is itself a form of power.
- **Johannes Fabian, *Time and the Other* (1983).** Ethnography placed living people in another time — "primitive", "traditional" — the **denial of coevalness** (allochronism).
- **Geertz's interpretive turn.** Culture as text, anthropology as interpretation (1973), the anthropologist as author — *Works and Lives* (1988) analysed Malinowski, Evans-Pritchard, Benedict and Lévi-Strauss as writers. *6-H*
- **Experimental ethnographies.** Rabinow, *Reflections on Fieldwork in Morocco* (1977); Crapanzano, *Tuhami: Portrait of a Moroccan* (1980); Dwyer, *Moroccan Dialogues* (1982); Shostak, *Nisa* (1981) — the fieldworker and the informant made visible.
- **Feminism.** It asked whose experience had counted as "the culture", and was itself a source of reflexivity.

5.4 The anthropological canon — 1986 and after

- **The Santa Fe seminar (1984)** at the School of American Research produced **James Clifford & George Marcus (eds.), *Writing Culture: The Poetics and Politics of Ethnography* (1986)**. Contributors included Clifford, Marcus, Rabinow, Crapanzano, Rosaldo, Asad, Pratt, Fischer and Tyler.
- **Clifford's introduction, "Partial Truths".** Ethnography is writing — rhetorical, institutional, generic, political, historical. Ethnographic truths are **"inherently partial — committed and incomplete"**. MEMORISE
- **Clifford, "On Ethnographic Authority" (1983).** Four modes of authority: **experiential** ("I was there"), **interpretive**, **dialogic** and **polyphonic**. The last two are the postmodern ideal.
- **Marcus & Fischer, *Anthropology as Cultural Critique: An Experimental Moment in the Human Sciences* (1986).** A **"crisis of representation"** across the human sciences; an "experimental moment" in writing; and anthropology's task as **cultural critique** of the anthropologist's own society.
- **Tyler, "Post-Modern Ethnography: From Document of the Occult to Occult Document" (1986).** Ethnography should not represent but **evoke** — a cooperative, fragmentary text that conjures a possible world in the minds of reader and writer. The most radical essay in the volume. *He had defined cognitive anthropology in 1969 — 6-I.*
- **Renato Rosaldo, *Culture and Truth: The Remaking of Social Analysis* (1989).** His essay on Ilongot headhunting understood only after his own wife's death — the **positioned subject**.
- **Lila Abu-Lughod, "Writing against Culture" (1991).** The concept of "a culture" fixes difference and hierarchy; write "ethnographies of the particular" instead.
- **Gupta & Ferguson, "Beyond 'Culture'" (1992); *Anthropological Locations* (1997).** Culture is not tied to a bounded place; the field/home divide is constructed.
- **George Marcus, "Ethnography in/of the World System: The Emergence of Multi-Sited Ethnography" (1995).** Follow the people, the thing, the metaphor, the conflict — the 2025 note.
- **Arjun Appadurai, "Disjuncture and Difference in the Global Cultural Economy" (1990); *Modernity at Large* (1996).** Five "scapes" of global flow — the 2024 culture question.

5.5 The basic features of postmodern anthropology — the 2015 question

Plain version. Ten things a postmodern anthropologist believes or does. Each needs a name attached.

#	Feature	What it means	Anthropologist
1	Crisis of representation	No account can simply mirror another culture; all are constructions	Marcus & Fischer 1986
2	Rejection of metanarratives	No master theory — evolutionism, functionalism, structuralism, Marxism — has the last word	Lyotard 1979; Marcus & Fischer
3	Ethnography as text	Writing is rhetoric, genre and allegory; truths are partial	Clifford 1986; Geertz 1988
4	Reflexivity	The author's position — gender, nation, power — enters the analysis	Rabinow 1977; Rosaldo 1989
5	Polyphony and dialogue	Many voices; informants as co-authors; dialogic authority	Clifford 1983; Crapanzano 1980; Dwyer 1982
6	Culture as contested and open	Not a bounded, integrated whole but plural, hybrid and changing	Abu-Lughod 1991; Gupta & Ferguson 1992
7	Power/knowledge and the colonial critique	Anthropological categories carry the power that produced them	Foucault; Asad 1973; Said 1978; Fabian 1983
8	Epistemological relativism	No neutral standpoint from which to judge accounts	Tyler 1986 (strong); Clifford (moderate)
9	Experimental writing	Life histories, dialogues, fragments, evocation in place of the monograph	Shostak 1981; Tyler 1986
10	Multi-sited and global	Follow flows across places; the world system in the local	Marcus 1995; Appadurai 1996

> **The line that lifts a features answer.** "Postmodern anthropology is less a new theory of culture than a new theory of ethnography: it asks not what culture is, but who has the authority to describe it, and how."

5.6 Derrida and deconstruction — the 2024 question

Plain version. Derrida showed that the paired opposites our thinking depends on — speech and writing, nature and culture, civilised and primitive — are never equal. One side is always ranked above the other, and that ranking can be exposed, turned upside down and then unsettled. That way of reading is deconstruction.

Who and what

- **Jacques Derrida (1930–2004)**, Algerian-born French philosopher. Three books in 1967: *Of Grammatology*, *Writing and Difference*, *Speech and Phenomena*.
- **"Structure, Sign and Play in the Discourse of the Human Sciences"** (Johns Hopkins, October 1966) — the founding lecture of post-structuralism, and a critique of **Lévi-Strauss**.

The concepts

Concept	Meaning
Logocentrism	Western thought's assumption that meaning is fully present in a centre — reason, truth, God, the speaking subject
Phonocentrism	The privilege of speech over writing, as if speech were closer to the speaker's meaning
Binary opposition	Paired concepts that are not neutral: one term is privileged, the other defined as its lack
Différance	Meaning arises from **difference** between signs and is endlessly **deferred** along the chain — never finally present
Trace	Each sign carries traces of the signs it is not
Supplement	What is added as secondary turns out to be necessary — as writing "supplements" speech

Concept	Meaning
“Il n’y a pas de hors-texte”	“There is nothing outside the text” — not that the world is unreal, but that nothing reaches us outside some system of signs and context

The operation — a reading strategy, not destruction

- **Identify** the binary that structures a text.
- **Expose** the hierarchy — which term is privileged and how.
- **Reverse** it — show the subordinate term is presupposed by the dominant one.
- **Displace** it — show the opposition is unstable; neither term stands alone. Deconstruction is not a method that ends in a new truth, but a practice of reading.

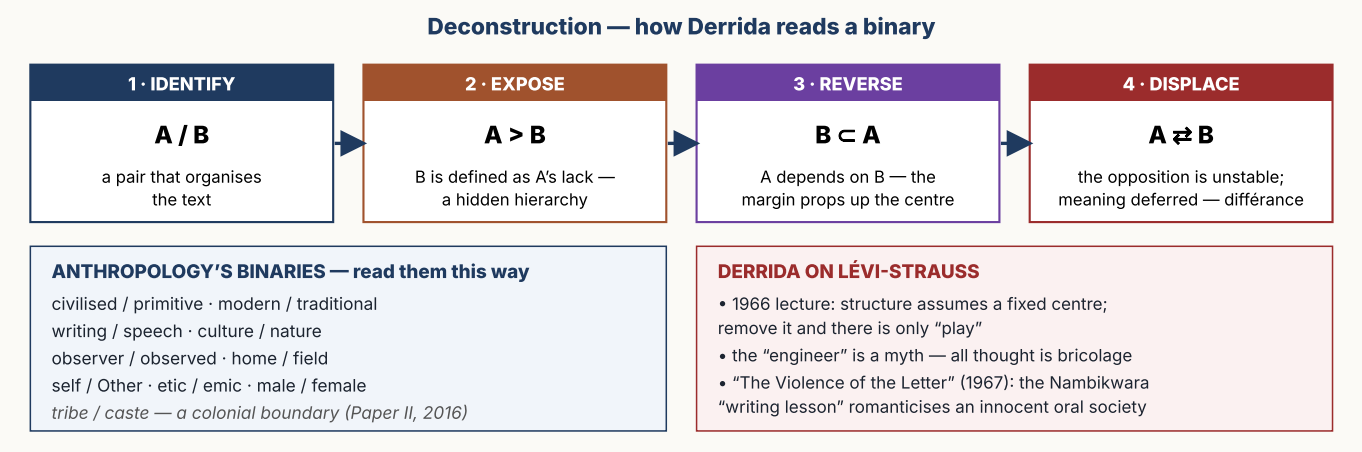


Fig. 2 — deconstruction as a four-step reading, with the binaries an anthropologist can apply it to and Derrida’s two critiques of Lévi-Strauss. Draw the top row for the 2024 question.

Derrida and anthropology — the point that lifts the 2024 answer

- **The critique of Lévi-Strauss.** In “Structure, Sign and Play” Derrida argued that structuralism needs a centre that is itself outside the play of the structure. Once the centre is denied, there is only a field of infinite substitutions. Lévi-Strauss’s distinction between the **bricoleur** and the **engineer** collapses, because no thinker builds from first principles.
- **“The Violence of the Letter: From Lévi-Strauss to Rousseau”** in *Of Grammatology*. In *Tristes Tropiques* (1955) Lévi-Strauss told how a Nambikwara chief imitated writing to gain power, and concluded that writing serves domination. Derrida replied that this romanticises an innocent, speech-only society: violence and classification — naming, prohibiting, marking — exist in every society before alphabetic writing (“arche-writing”). The praise of the “primitive” is **ethnocentrism in reverse**.
- **Ethnography as writing.** Clifford’s “partial truths” and Tyler’s “evocation” apply Derrida’s point to the monograph: the ethnographer’s authority rests on a text, not on presence in the field.
- **Deconstructing categories.** “Primitive”, “tribe”, “caste”, “Hindu” can be shown to rest on hierarchical oppositions made in particular histories — the move behind Cohn’s and Dirks’s work on India and behind “tribe as a colonial construct”.

Criticism of deconstruction

- **Obscurity and textualism** — everything becomes text; the material world, labour and violence recede.
- **Relativism and nihilism** — if meaning is endlessly deferred, no interpretation can be preferred; Habermas charged it with abandoning reason.
- **Political quietism** — critique without a programme (though Derrida later wrote on justice and law, “Force of Law”, 1990).
- **Misreading risk** — “nothing outside the text” is often wrongly read as denying reality; say what it means.
- **For anthropology** — the method suits texts better than fieldwork; Spiro and Harris saw it as an end to empirical science.

5.7 Postmodernism, social justice and the marginalised — the 2025 question

Plain version. Postmodern theory hands marginalised people tools to question the stories told about them and to be heard on their own terms. But by doubting all universal truths it can also weaken the very claims of rights and justice they need.

What it offers

Tool	How it helps the marginalised	Case
Deconstructing dominant narratives	Shows that "development", "progress" and "primitive" are discourses that justify intervention and dispossession	Escobar, *Encountering Development* 1995; Ferguson, *The Anti-Politics Machine* 1990
Power/knowledge	Asks whose knowledge counts; legitimises indigenous and local knowledge against expert monopoly	Foucault; FRA 2006 community rights; TEK
Exposing constructed categories	Labels made by power can be unmade: criminal tribe, primitive tribe	Criminal Tribes Act 1871, repealed 1952; PTG renamed PVTG
Voice and polyphony	The studied speak for themselves; life histories and testimony	Subaltern Studies (Guha, 1982 on); Spivak 1988
Situated knowledge and standpoint	Experience of the oppressed as a source of theory, not only data	Haraway 1988; Gopal Guru 2002
Reflexive, collaborative research	Communities as partners; consent; benefit-sharing	Participatory research; ethics codes
Recognition of plural identities	Gender, sexuality, caste and indigeneity as legitimate identities	Butler 1990; Dalit and Adivasi assertion

> **The Indian case to carry.** At **Niyamgiri** in Odisha, the Supreme Court (2013) required the **gram sabhas** of the Dongria Kondh to decide whether bauxite mining would affect their religious and cultural rights; all twelve sabhas consulted rejected it. A local, sacred, non-expert understanding of a mountain prevailed over a national development narrative — postmodern scepticism of the metanarrative, turned into a legal voice through PESA and the FRA.

Where it fails them

- **Relativism undercuts rights.** If every truth is partial, the claim that untouchability or land grabbing is *wrong* loses its universal ground. Human rights are a metanarrative the poor need.
- **Fragmentation weakens solidarity.** Endless difference splits the collective subjects — workers, Adivasis, women — that mobilise.
- **Discourse over material conditions.** Land, wages, hunger and violence are not texts; Marxist and materialist critics say it turned scholarship away from political economy (Harris 1999).
- **Elitist prose.** A theory of voice written in prose the marginalised cannot read; Nussbaum's attack on Butler, "The Professor of Parody" (1999).
- **Spivak's own warning.** "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988): well-meaning intellectuals who "give voice" may speak over the subaltern.

The resolution — what to write in the conclusion

- **Strategic essentialism** (Spivak): use a shared identity politically while knowing it is constructed.
- **Critically applied anthropology**: keep the critique of power and the commitment to justice together — Scheper-Hughes, "The Primacy of the Ethical: Propositions for a Militant Anthropology" (1995).
- **Ground the voice in law and institutions**: PESA 1996, FRA 2006, the Niyamgiri gram sabhas — deconstruction of the metanarrative made effective by rights.



Fig. 3 — the three-column ledger that carries the 2025 answer: what postmodern theory gives the marginalised, what it costs them, and the position that keeps both.

5.8 The internal critique — feminists and others

- **Clifford's exclusion.** His introduction admitted feminists were absent from *Writing Culture*, arguing that feminist ethnography had changed content more than textual form. The reply was sharp.
- **Mascia-Lees, Sharpe & Cohen, "The Postmodernist Turn in Anthropology: Cautions from a Feminist Perspective" (*Signs*, 1989).** Feminism had long questioned objectivity and voice, and had a political goal; postmodernism borrowed the first and dropped the second.
- **Ruth Behar & Deborah Gordon (eds.), *Women Writing Culture* (1995)** — the answer volume.
- **Abu-Lughod (1991)** — feminists and "halfies" (people of mixed national or cultural identity) were already writing against culture.
- **Native and Third-World anthropologists** pointed out that decolonising anthropology had been their project for decades — Faye Harrison (ed.), *Decolonizing Anthropology* (1991).

5.9 Criticism and legacy

Criticism	The point	Who
Anti-science and relativism	Abandons the comparative, empirical project; no criterion to prefer one account	Spiro 1996 (*CSSH*); D'Andrade 1995
Obscurantism	Jargon and idealism; ignores material causes	Harris, *Theories of Culture in Postmodern Times* 1999
Navel-gazing	The anthropologist becomes the subject; the people vanish again	General; Sangren 1988 (*Current Anthropology*)
Rationalist objection	Postmodernism as fashion; relativism as a dead end	Gellner, *Postmodernism, Reason and Religion* 1992
Moral versus objective	Confuses moral advocacy with knowledge claims	D'Andrade, "Moral Models in Anthropology" 1995
Western academic irony	A critique of Western authority written mainly by Western academics	Harrison 1991; Indian critics

The legacy, which is what an examiner wants as the verdict. As a programme for writing it faded by the late 1990s; as a **sensibility** it won. Reflexivity, ethics, consent, collaboration, attention to voice and power, multi-sited fieldwork and the critique of bounded "cultures" are now ordinary anthropology. Even critics write differently because of it.

5.10 India — where to use it

- **Subaltern Studies** (Ranajit Guha, from 1982) — history from below; Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) as its self-critique.
- **Colonial knowledge.** Bernard Cohn, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge* (1996) — the census and ethnographic survey as technologies of rule; Nicholas Dirks, *Castes of Mind* (2001) — caste hardened by colonial

classification; Ronald Inden, *Imagining India* (1990). Use for the 2024 Paper II "deconstruct the colonial history" question, balanced with Srinivas and Dumont.

- **"Tribe" as a category.** The colonial tribe/caste boundary and the administrative Scheduled Tribe list as constructions — the 2016 Paper II note; Virginius Xaxa on tribes as indigenous people (1999).
- **Voices from below.** Gloria Raheja & Ann Gold, *Listen to the Heron's Words* (1994) — women's songs reworking kinship and gender; Veena Das, *Critical Events* (1995).
- **Who theorises.** Gopal Guru, "How Egalitarian Are the Social Sciences in India?" (2002) — "theoretical Brahmins and empirical Shudras"; Guru & Sarukkai, *The Cracked Mirror* (2012). The strongest Indian line for the 2025 question.
- **A reflexive precursor.** M. N. Srinivas wrote *The Remembered Village* (1976) from memory after his Rampura field notes were destroyed in a fire at Stanford in 1970 — an ethnography that openly foregrounds the author's recollection.
- **Niyamgiri (2013)** — local sacred knowledge against a development metanarrative (5.7).

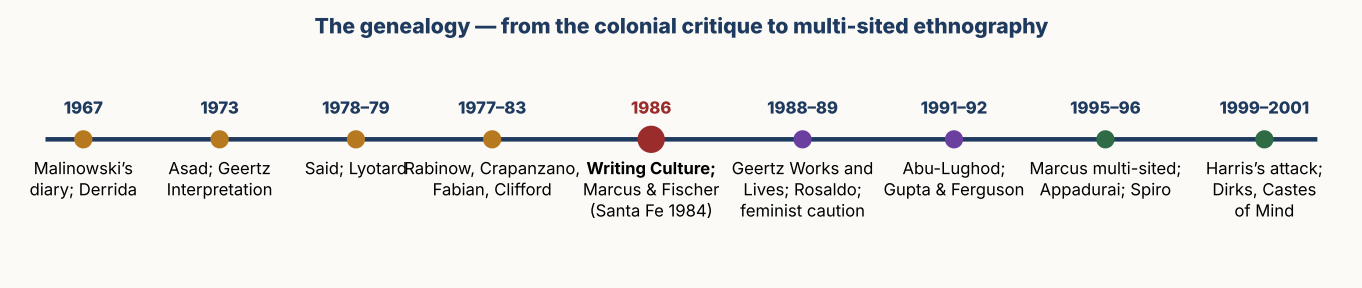


Fig. 4 — the genealogy in nine points. 1986 is the hinge; the decade after it is the internal critique and the move to the global.

6 WHAT TO MEMORISE VERSUS WHAT TO UNDERSTAND

Tier	Content
MEMORISE word for word	Lyotard 1979 "incredulity toward metanarratives" • Clifford 1986 "partial — committed and incomplete" • *Writing Culture* (Clifford & Marcus 1986; Santa Fe 1984) • Marcus & Fischer 1986 "crisis of representation", "cultural critique" • Clifford's four modes of authority • Derrida 1966 and 1967 titles • différance = differ + defer • "there is nothing outside the text" and what it means • the four steps of deconstruction • Fabian's denial of coevalness • Spivak 1988 and strategic essentialism • Gopal Guru 2002
UNDERSTAND and reproduce flexibly	The ten features with a name each • why the turn happened • how Derrida reads Lévi-Strauss • why deconstruction is not destruction • the gives/costs/resolution ledger for justice • why feminists objected • the legacy as sensibility • the Niyamgiri case
CONCEPTUAL recall only	Baudrillard and Jameson beyond one line • Tyler's essay title in full • Sangren, Gellner, D'Andrade details • Raheja & Gold, Veena Das • Inden • Habermas's objection

7 HIGH-ROI FACTUAL ANCHORS

Item	What to remember	Why it matters in an answer	Memory hook
Lyotard, 1979	*The Postmodern Condition*; incredulity toward metanarratives	The definition	No big stories
Derrida, 1966 / 1967	"Structure, Sign and Play"; *Of Grammatology*; différance	2024; critique of Lévi-Strauss	Differ and defer
Foucault, 1969–76	Power/knowledge; discourse	Whose knowledge counts	Knowledge is power's tool
Asad, 1973	*Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter*	Colonial critique	Born in empire

Item	What to remember	Why it matters in an answer	Memory hook
Said, 1978	*Orientalism*	Representation as domination	The East invented
Fabian, 1983	*Time and the Other*; denial of coevalness	"Primitive" as another time	Same time, denied
Clifford & Marcus, 1986	*Writing Culture*; "Partial Truths"	The canon	Santa Fe '84
Marcus & Fischer, 1986	Crisis of representation; cultural critique	The diagnosis	Experimental moment
Tyler, 1986	Evocation, not representation	The radical pole; bridge to 6-I	Evoke, don't mirror
Rosaldo, 1989	*Culture and Truth*; positioned subject	Reflexivity	Grief and rage
Abu-Lughod, 1991	"Writing against Culture"	Culture not bounded	Against "a culture"
Marcus, 1995	Multi-sited ethnography	2025 note	Follow the thing
Spivak, 1988	"Can the Subaltern Speak?"; strategic essentialism	2025 limits and fix	Who speaks for whom
Gopal Guru, 2002	Theoretical Brahmins, empirical Shudras	Indian justice line	Who theorises
Niyamgiri, 2013	Dongria Kondh gram sabhas reject mining	Indian application	Mountain as voice
Spiro, 1996 / Harris, 1999	Modernist and materialist critiques	The "critically" half	Science strikes back

8 TECHNICAL VOCABULARY BANK

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Metanarrative	A grand story claiming to explain everything	Definition	"Evolutionism was anthropology's first metanarrative."
Crisis of representation	Doubt that any text can truly depict another culture	Features; 2020	"The crisis of representation made every monograph suspect."
Reflexivity	The author examining their own position and influence	Features; ethics	"Reflexivity puts the fieldworker inside the analysis."
Polyphony	Many voices in one text	Features	"Polyphonic ethnography lets informants speak in their own words."
Ethnographic authority	The basis on which a writer claims to know	Clifford	"Experiential authority rested on having been there."
Partial truths	Accounts that are committed and incomplete	Clifford	"All ethnographic truths are partial truths."
Deconstruction	Reading that exposes and unsettles a text's binaries	2024	"Deconstruction reverses and displaces the civilised/primitive pair."
Différance	Meaning made by difference and endlessly deferred	2024	"Différance denies any final, present meaning."
Logocentrism	Belief in a fixed centre of meaning	2024	"Derrida found logocentrism even in structuralism."
Power/knowledge	Knowledge produced within, and serving, power	2025; colonialism	"Colonial census categories show power/knowledge at work."
Denial of coevalness	Placing living others in a past time	Colonial critique	"Calling tribes 'primitive' denies their coevalness."

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Subaltern	Those outside the structures of power and representation	2025; India	"The subaltern is spoken about more than heard."
Strategic essentialism	Using a shared identity politically, knowing it is constructed	2025 conclusion	"Adivasi movements practise strategic essentialism."
Multi-sited ethnography	Fieldwork that follows people and things across places	2025 note	"Multi-sited ethnography follows the commodity, not the village."

9 ANSWER EXPRESSION TOOLKIT

Definitions to reproduce

- **Postmodernism:** a late-twentieth-century movement that rejects universal truths and grand theories, treats knowledge and identity as constructed, plural and bound up with power, and attends to language, representation and the position of the knower.
- **Postmodern anthropology:** the reflexive and literary turn of the 1980s that questioned ethnographic authority and representation, rejected master paradigms, and sought plural, dialogic and positioned accounts of culture.
- **Deconstruction:** Derrida's practice of reading that identifies a text's governing binary, exposes its hidden hierarchy, reverses it and displaces it, showing that meaning is never fully present.

Introductions

- (Features) "Postmodern anthropology is less a new theory of culture than a new theory of ethnography: it asks who has the authority to describe a culture, and how."
- (Derrida) "Deconstruction is not destruction but a way of reading: it shows that the oppositions our thought rests on are hierarchies, and that the subordinate term props up the dominant one."
- (Justice) "By doubting the grand narratives that justified domination, postmodernism gave the marginalised tools of critique; by doubting all narratives, it risked disarming them."

Analytical and transition lines

- "Geertz made the anthropologist an author; the postmodernists asked what gives the author authority."
- "Clifford's point is not that ethnography is false but that its truths are partial — committed and incomplete."
- "Derrida's reading of the Nambikwara writing lesson turns Lévi-Strauss's praise of the primitive into ethnocentrism in reverse."
- "Niyamgiri shows a development metanarrative defeated not by theory alone but by a local voice given legal standing."

Criticism and qualification lines

- "If all truths are partial, the claim that dispossession is unjust needs a ground postmodernism cannot easily supply."
- "The reflexive turn sometimes replaced the people studied with the anthropologist studying."
- "Feminists had questioned objectivity first, and noticed that *Writing Culture* left them out."

Conclusions

- "As a programme for writing it faded; as a sensibility — reflexive, ethical, attentive to voice and power — it became ordinary anthropology."
- "The mature position keeps postmodernism's critique of power and anthropology's commitment to evidence and justice together."

India linkages

- Subaltern Studies and Spivak • Cohn 1996 and Dirks 2001 on colonial knowledge • "tribe as colonial construct" • Gopal Guru 2002 • Raheja & Gold 1994 • Srinivas, *The Remembered Village* 1976 • Niyamgiri 2013 • PVTG renaming.

10 DIAGRAM BANK

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	How to reproduce in about 30 seconds
Fig. 1 — crisis of representation	HIGHEST ROI — draw it	2012, 2015, 2025, 2020	Two columns, realist and postmodern, eight rows (authority, voice, culture, time, theory, text, aim, exemplar), an arrow through a middle box of pressures
Fig. 2 — deconstruction	Draw for 2024	Derrida	Four boxes: A/B → A>B → B⊂A → A⇄B; below, three anthropology binaries
Fig. 3 — justice ledger	Draw for 2025	Application questions	Three columns: gives, costs, resolution — one Indian case in the last
Fig. 4 — genealogy	Optional	Long answers	A line 1967 → 1973 → 1978 → 1986 (circled) → 1991 → 1995

Examiner's-eye view. For a 20-mark answer, one figure is enough — Fig. 1 for features, Fig. 2 for Derrida, Fig. 3 for justice. What lifts any of them is **anthropologists** attached to each point, and one Indian case.

11 COMPARISONS AND DEBATES

11.1 Realist against postmodern ethnography

See Fig. 1, which is the comparison in full. The bases that do the work are authority, voice, the concept of culture, and the status of the text.

11.2 Interpretive (Geertz) against postmodern

Basis	Geertz, interpretive	Postmodern
Culture as text	Yes — to be read by the anthropologist	Yes — but the reading is itself a text to be questioned
Authority	Retained: the interpreter reads "over the shoulders" of natives	Questioned: dialogue, polyphony, co-authorship
Culture	Integrated webs of significance	Contested, fragmented, plural
Power	Largely absent	Central
Relation	Geertz is the precursor; *Works and Lives* (1988) is his own contribution to the textual critique	

11.3 Structuralism against post-structuralism

Basis	Lévi-Strauss	Derrida
Structure	Stable, centred, universal	Decentred; a field of free play
Binaries	Mediated in myth	Hierarchies to be reversed and displaced
Meaning	Determined by position in the system	Endlessly deferred — différance
Science	Anthropology as science of the mind	No position outside the text
Writing	Linked to domination (Nambikwara)	Violence precedes writing; no innocent society

11.4 Postmodernism against Marxism on justice

Basis	Postmodernism	Marxism
Source of oppression	Discourse, categories, representation	Relations of production, property
Subject of change	Plural identities and voices	A class
Grand narrative	Rejected	Itself one
Weakness	Relativism; fragmentation	Neglects caste, gender, culture

12 MASTER QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

MASTER ANSWER 1 (20 marks). "Explain the basic features of 'Postmodernism' in Anthropology." (2015)

How to structure it. Define and place it; one paragraph on why it arose; then the features, each with an anthropologist; Fig. 1; close on criticism and legacy.

Postmodernism rejects universal truths and grand theories — Lyotard's "incredulity toward metanarratives" (1979) — and treats knowledge as constructed, plural and tied to power. In anthropology it became, in the 1980s, a critique less of what culture is than of **how anthropologists know and write it**.

It arose from decolonisation and the colonial critique (Asad 1973), the publication of Malinowski's diary (1967), Said's *Orientalism* (1978), Fabian's exposure of the "denial of coevalness" (1983) and Geertz's turn to culture as text. Its charter is Clifford and Marcus, *Writing Culture* (1986).

Features. (1) A **crisis of representation**: no account mirrors another culture (Marcus and Fischer 1986). (2) **No master paradigm**: evolutionism, functionalism and structuralism lose their claim to the last word. (3) **Ethnography as text**: its truths are "partial — committed and incomplete" (Clifford). (4) **Reflexivity**: the author's position enters the analysis, as in Rabinow's Moroccan fieldwork (1977) and Rosaldo's Ilongot essay (1989). (5) **Polyphony and dialogue**: informants as co-authors (Crapanzano's *Tuhami*, Dwyer's *Moroccan Dialogues*). (6) **Culture as contested** rather than a bounded whole — Abu-Lughod's "Writing against Culture" (1991). (7) **Power/knowledge**: categories such as "primitive" and "tribe" carry colonial power (Foucault, Said). (8) **Relativism** of standpoint. (9) **Experimental writing** — life histories, dialogues, Tyler's "evocation". (10) **Multi-sited** study of global flows (Marcus 1995; Appadurai).

[Draw Fig. 1: realist against postmodern ethnography.]

Assessment. Critics charged relativism and anti-science (Spiro 1996), idealism (Harris 1999) and self-absorption; feminists noted their own exclusion from *Writing Culture* (Mascia-Lees et al. 1989). In India it shaped Subaltern Studies and the reading of caste and tribe as colonial categories (Cohn, Dirks).

As a programme for writing it faded; as a sensibility — reflexive, ethical, alert to voice and power — it became ordinary anthropology.

About 340 words plus the figure — right for 20 marks. The anthropologist attached to each feature is what separates this from a philosophy answer.

MASTER ANSWER 2 (20 marks). "Critically explain the notion of 'deconstruction' in the light of the postmodern works of Jacques Derrida." (2024)

Jacques Derrida (1930–2004) introduced deconstruction in his 1966 lecture "Structure, Sign and Play" and in *Of Grammatology* and *Writing and Difference* (1967). It is not destruction but a **practice of reading** that unsettles the assumptions a text depends on.

The target: logocentrism. Western thought assumes a centre where meaning is fully present — reason, truth, the speaking subject — and privileges speech over writing (phonocentrism). It is organised by **binary oppositions** — speech/writing, nature/culture, civilised/primitive — which are never neutral: one term is ranked above the other.

The operation. Deconstruction identifies the binary, exposes the hierarchy, **reverses** it by showing the dominant term depends on the subordinate, and then **displaces** it, showing the opposition cannot stand. Meaning, Derrida

argues, arises from difference between signs and is endlessly deferred — ***différance***; each sign carries the **trace** of others. "There is nothing outside the text" means not that the world is unreal, but that nothing reaches us outside some system of signs. *[Fig. 2, top row.]*

Anthropology. Derrida's first targets were anthropological. He argued that Lévi-Strauss's structuralism needs a fixed centre, and that his engineer/bricoleur contrast collapses. In "The Violence of the Letter" he read the Nambikwara "writing lesson" of *Tristes Tropiques* and showed that Lévi-Strauss romanticised an innocent oral society — ethnocentrism in reverse. Through Clifford's "partial truths" and Tyler's "evocation", ethnography itself came to be read as a text, and categories such as **primitive, tribe and caste** were deconstructed as colonial constructions (Cohn; Dirks).

Critique. Deconstruction has been charged with obscurity and textualism, which let material inequality recede; with relativism, since no reading can be preferred (Habermas); and with political quietism, though Derrida later wrote on justice ("Force of Law", 1990). Empirical anthropologists such as Spiro saw it as an end to science.

Its lasting value is a habit of suspicion: any anthropological opposition — self and Other, home and field, modern and traditional — should be asked whose hierarchy it encodes.

About 350 words. Two things lift it: the Lévi-Strauss critique, and the correct reading of "nothing outside the text".

MASTER ANSWER 3 (20 marks). "How the theories of postmodernism are relevant in promoting social justice and empowerment of marginalised communities?" (2025)

Postmodern theory distrusts the grand narratives — progress, development, civilisation — by which dominant groups have justified power, and treats knowledge as bound up with that power (Foucault). This makes it a resource for the marginalised, and also a risk.

How it helps. First, it **deconstructs dominant narratives**: Escobar (1995) and Ferguson (1990) showed "development" as a discourse that depoliticises dispossession. Second, it shows that **categories are constructed** and can be unmade — the "criminal tribes" of the 1871 Act, denotified in 1952, and the shift from "Primitive" to "Particularly Vulnerable" Tribal Groups. Third, it asks **whose knowledge counts**, legitimising indigenous knowledge, now recognised in the Forest Rights Act 2006. Fourth, through **polyphony and voice** it lets the studied speak — Subaltern Studies' history from below. Fifth, **situated knowledge** makes experience a source of theory: Gopal Guru's critique of "theoretical Brahmins and empirical Shudras" (2002). Sixth, reflexive, collaborative research gives communities a say over how they are represented.

The Indian case. At Niyamgiri (2013) the Supreme Court let Dongria Kondh gram sabhas decide whether mining affected their sacred and cultural rights; they rejected it. A local understanding defeated a national development narrative. *[Fig. 3.]*

Limits. Relativism can undercut universal rights — the ground on which untouchability or land alienation is condemned. Endless difference fragments the collectives that mobilise. Its focus on discourse can neglect land, wages and violence (Harris). Its prose excludes those it speaks of, and, as Spivak warned in "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988), intellectuals may speak over the subaltern.

Resolution. Spivak's **strategic essentialism**, Scheper-Hughes's ethically committed anthropology (1995), and institutional voice through PESA 1996 and FRA 2006 keep the critique while restoring the commitment. Postmodernism empowers the marginalised when its suspicion of power is joined to a defence of rights.

About 340 words. The stem says "how ... relevant", so the gains come first and take the most space; the limits are what make it critical.

MASTER ANSWER 4 (10–12 marks, about 150 words). "Post-modernism in Anthropology." (2012)

Postmodernism rejects universal truths and grand theories — Lyotard's "incredulity toward metanarratives" (1979). In anthropology it became the reflexive turn of the 1980s, crystallised in Clifford and Marcus's *Writing Culture* (1986) and Marcus and Fischer's diagnosis of a "crisis of representation".

Its features are: ethnography seen as a text whose truths are "partial" (Clifford); reflexivity about the author's position; polyphony and dialogue with informants; culture as contested rather than bounded (Abu-Lughod); attention to power and colonial knowledge (Asad, Said, Fabian); and experimental writing, from life histories to Tyler's "evocation".

Critics such as Spiro and Harris charged it with relativism and neglect of material reality, and feminists noted their exclusion. Yet reflexivity, ethics and multi-sited fieldwork are now standard practice.

About 150 words.

13 MAINS QUESTION BANK

#	Question	Marks	Tags
1	Post-modernism in anthropology.	10	H R S
2	Crisis of representation.	10	R S
3	Reflexivity in ethnography.	10	R S
4	Multi-sited ethnography.	10	H S
5	Explain the basic features of postmodernism in anthropology.	20	H R D S
6	Critically explain deconstruction in the light of Derrida's works.	20	H R D S
7	How are postmodern theories relevant to social justice and the empowerment of marginalised communities?	20	H R D S I
8	Examine the contribution of *Writing Culture* (1986) to anthropology.	15	R S
9	Discuss Foucault's idea of power/knowledge and its use in anthropology.	15	S I
10	How have interpretation and presentation of data changed from classical to contemporary anthropological texts?	15	H D S
11	Distinguish Geertz's interpretive anthropology from postmodern anthropology.	15	S
12	"Postmodernism ended anthropology as a science." Critically examine.	20	S
13	Deconstruct the category of 'tribe' in India.	15	S I
14	Discuss the feminist critique of postmodern anthropology.	15	S

H = asked or near-verbatim • R = high ROI • D = needs a diagram • S = needs a scholar or ethnographic case • I = needs an India linkage.

14 CLOSED-BOOK RECALL DRILL

Core concepts (5)

- Lyotard's definition, with year and book.
- The crisis of representation in two sentences, with its source.
- Ten features of postmodern anthropology, each with a name.
- Clifford's four modes of ethnographic authority.
- Deconstruction's four steps and the meaning of différance.

Factual anchors (5)

- Editors, year and seminar of *Writing Culture*.
- Clifford's phrase on ethnographic truths, word for word.

Comparisons (3)

- Realist against postmodern ethnography on eight bases.
- Geertz against the postmodernists on four bases.
- Lévi-Strauss against Derrida on five bases.

Critical judgement (2)

- Six criticisms, four with names.
- Gives, costs and resolution for the marginalised.

Diagram reproduction (2)

- Draw Fig. 1 with all eight rows and the pressures box.
- Draw Fig. 2's four steps with three anthropology binaries.

- Derrida's two critiques of Lévi-Strauss, with titles.
- Asad, Said, Fabian — book and year each.
- The Niyamgiri facts in three lines.

Timed notes (2)

- In twenty minutes, write the 2025 answer. Count the Indian cases.
- In eight minutes, write the 150-word 2012 note.

15 ONE-PAGE QUICK-REVISION SHEET

THE SPINE

No metanarrative (Lyotard 1979) → **ethnography is writing**, truths partial (Clifford 1986) → **power/knowledge** and the colonial critique (Foucault; Asad 1973; Said 1978; Fabian 1983) → **reflexivity, polyphony, open culture**, experimental texts → **gains and costs**: voice and critique against relativism and navel-gazing. A theory of ethnography more than of culture. Faded as programme; won as sensibility.

ESSENTIAL TERMS

metanarrative • crisis of representation • partial truths • ethnographic authority (experiential, interpretive, dialogic, polyphonic) • reflexivity • polyphony • denial of coevalness • power/knowledge • deconstruction • logocentrism • différance • trace • subaltern • strategic essentialism • multi-sited

ESSENTIAL CASES

Malinowski's diary • Nambikwara writing lesson • Tuhami • Moroccan Dialogues • Nisa • Ilongot grief and rage • Bedouin (Abu-Lughod) • development in Lesotho (Ferguson) • criminal tribes • PTG → PVTG • Niyamgiri 2013 • Rampura remembered

ESSENTIAL SCHOLARS

Lyotard 1979 • Derrida 1966/67 • Foucault • Asad 1973 • Said 1978 • Rabinow 1977 • Fabian 1983 • Clifford 1983/86 • Marcus & Fischer 1986 • Tyler 1986 • Geertz 1988 • Rosaldo 1989 • Abu-Lughod 1991 • Marcus 1995 • Spivak 1988 • Escobar 1995 • Spiro 1996 • Harris 1999 • Guru 2002

THE THREE LINES TO HAVE WORD-PERFECT

- 1. The postmodern is incredulity toward metanarratives. (Lyotard, 1979)
- 2. Ethnographic truths are inherently partial — committed and incomplete. (Clifford, 1986)
- 3. Postmodernism empowers the marginalised when its suspicion of power is joined to a defence of rights.

DIAGRAM CUES

Fig. 1 realist ↔ postmodern on eight rows, pressures in the middle • Fig. 2 A/B → A>B → B⊂A → A⇄B • Fig. 3 gives / costs / resolution.

THE INDIAN SET TO HAVE READY

Subaltern Studies, Spivak • Cohn 1996, Dirks 2001 — caste and tribe as colonial categories • Gopal Guru 2002 • Raheja & Gold 1994 • Srinivas 1976 • Niyamgiri 2013 • criminal tribes 1871/1952 • PVTG.

CONFUSIONS TO AVOID

- Deconstruction is **not destruction** — it is a reading that reverses and displaces.
- "Nothing outside the text" does **not** deny reality.
- Geertz is a **precursor**, not a postmodernist.
- Postmodernity (condition) ≠ postmodernism (theory).
- For "critically" stems, the limits are compulsory — never write a celebration.

16 SOURCES AND HONEST CAVEATS

What this note was built from

- **UPSC syllabus** — Paper I, clause 6(j).
- **PYQs** — your 1995–2021 topic-wise compilation (Vishnu IAS) for 2012 (12 marks) and 2015 (20 marks); Vaids ICS 2013–2025 compilation; published 2024, 2025 and 2026 Paper I texts (iasexamportal, Mrunal, Lotus Arise, Prepp). 2026 has no postmodernism stem.
- **Standard sources** — Lyotard (1979); Derrida (1966, 1967); Foucault; Asad (1973); Said (1978); Fabian (1983); Clifford (1983) and Clifford & Marcus (1986); Marcus & Fischer (1986); Geertz (1988); Rosaldo (1989); Abu-Lughod (1991); Gupta & Ferguson (1992); Marcus (1995); Spiro (1996); Harris (1999); Spivak (1988); Escobar (1995); Ferguson (1990).

- **Indian sources** — Guha; Cohn (1996); Dirks (2001); Gopal Guru (2002); Raheja & Gold (1994); Srinivas (1976); Supreme Court, *Orissa Mining Corporation v. Ministry of Environment and Forests* (2013).

Where you should be careful

- **2012 and 2015 wording is compilation-based**; your compilation gives 12 and 20 marks. The Vaids list shows the 2025 stem twice (15 and 20) — the published paper gives **20**.
- **PYQ count is 4.** Your tracker had 2. If your own audit counts pre-1995 askings, tell me and I will revise.
- **Quotations.** Lyotard's and Clifford's phrases are standard and safe word for word. Tyler's essay is paraphrased; do not quote it.
- **"Postmodern" is a contested label.** Clifford and Marcus disliked it for themselves; many textbooks call the movement the reflexive or literary turn. Say so in one line if you have space.
- **Niyamgiri.** The 2013 judgment directed the gram sabhas to decide on religious and cultural rights; twelve were consulted and all rejected the project. Present it as an application, not as a postmodern theorist's own case.
- **Srinivas.** *The Remembered Village* is a reflexive precursor, not a postmodern text. Use it as illustration only.